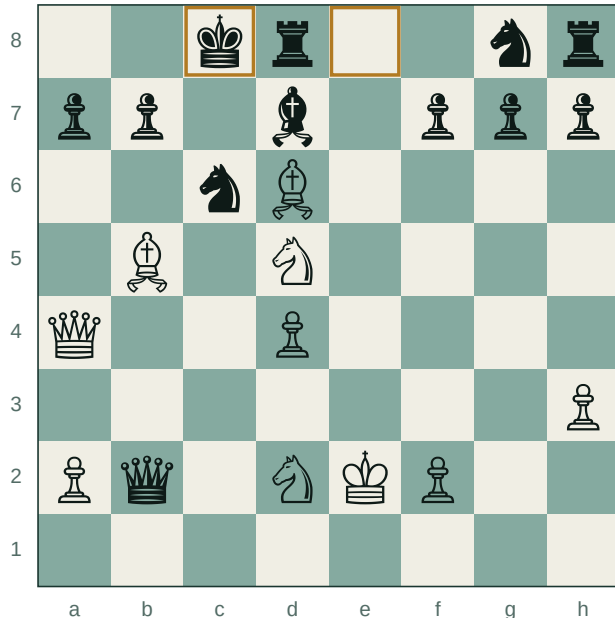


Mate in three: White, move 16

Mate in three

White to move



Previous move: 15...O-O-O. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

16. Nb6+ axb6 17. Qa8+ Nb8 18. Qxb8#

16.Nb6+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From b6 it attacks king on c8 and bishop on d7. Recorded reply: **16...axb6**.

17.Qa8+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **17...Nb8**.

18.Qxb8# Mate: queen on b8 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on c8. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Queen on b8. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not stop at a promising check. The final mating position must still be legal after every intervening move.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Longer mating lines require accurate visualization. Track the king's square, opened lines, and every sacrificed piece through the entire sequence.

HOW TO LOOK

Work backward from a mating pattern, then calculate forward with the opponent choosing the strongest defense.

The defending king is on c8. Geometrically undefended: rook on h8 and queen on b2. Check for tactical protection.